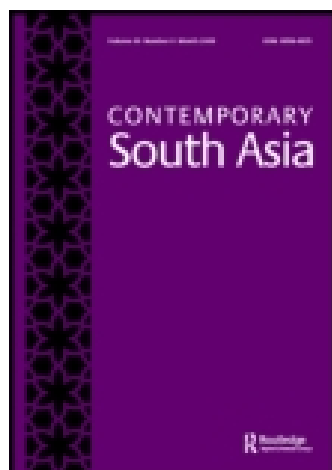


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Between the local and the diasporic: the shifting centre of gravity in war-torn Sri Lanka's transnational politics

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In May 2009, Sri Lankan government armed forces defeated the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) after more than a quarter of a century of civil war. With the elimination of most of the LTTE leadership and the waning of its hold over Tamils in Sri Lanka and abroad, the scene was set for a transformation of relations between the diaspora and those at home. It is the dynamics of this transformation that we explore in this article, which traces the shifting centre of gravity in Tamil politics between actors in the homeland and those in the diaspora. Drawing on Bourdieu's notion of a 'political field', we characterise what we call the local, diasporic and transnational political fields in the Sri Lankan setting. This article shows how the LTTE's power derived largely from its control of the transnational political field, including in places that were otherwise isolated from diasporic connections. The defeat in 2009 fundamentally changed the dynamics of transnational politics by greatly weakening the LTTE's grip over the transnational political field, and this article explores the new dispensation that is now unfolding.

Keywords: Sri Lanka; civil war; diaspora; transnationalism; political field

Introduction

In May 2009, Sri Lankan government armed forces defeated the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) after more than a quarter of a century of civil war. The conflict generated large-scale refugee flight over several decades, contributing to the formation of a substantial Tamil diaspora of around a million people (Fuglerud 1999; Venugopal 2006). Like other diasporas from conflict-ridden societies (Van Hear 1998, 2009), this transnational population has kept close contact with relatives and communities left behind and with political developments in the erstwhile homeland. As well as holding sway over much of the Tamil population in Sri Lanka, the LTTE had substantial influence among the Tamil diaspora, which is often cited as a classical example of support for insurgency (Wayland 2004). With the elimination of most of the LTTE leadership in 2009 and the waning of its hold over Tamils in Sri Lanka and abroad, the scene was set for a transformation of relations between the diaspora and those at home. It is the dynamics of this transformation that we explore in this article.

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To pursue this analysis, we juxtapose politics and political developments in Sri Lanka with corresponding developments in the Sri Lankan Tamil diaspora. We engage with both the 'local' and the 'transnational' by looking at some particular manifestations of Tamil politics and their relation to location, both geographical and social. In particular, we seek to understand what we call the Sri Lankan Tamil 'transnational political field' and how this field has changed over time. We focus on Sri Lankan Tamil politics in the wake of the escalation of civil war and the military defeat of the LTTE in May 2009. In the course of this analysis, we highlight the shifting centre of gravity in Tamil politics between actors in the homeland and those in the diaspora.

Our particular focus is the way in which LTTE control of the transnational political field ebbed and flowed until its defeat in May 2009, paving the way for a new dispensation in the political field. The empirical data come from several years of following the Sri Lankan conflict and the Tamil diaspora by the authors, individually and jointly (Brun 2005, 2008a, 2008b; Van Hear 2006, 2009). Gathered both in Sri Lanka and in the diaspora, the material derives from interviews with individuals, with local and transnational social, political, humanitarian and religious organisations, and with representatives from government and the LTTE, as well as participant observation in cultural events, political and social meetings and demonstrations. The material comes from interviews in Sri Lanka in Colombo, Jaffna and elsewhere in the north and eastern Sri Lanka from 2000 to 2011, and in London, the UK and Toronto, Canada, from 2003 to 2011.

In the next section, we attempt to characterise Sri Lankan Tamil politics in terms of Bourdieu's notion of a 'political field'. We then briefly outline processes of mobilisation and demobilisation among Tamils since independence in 1948. To illustrate these processes, this article turns to Tamil politics in a particular part of eastern Sri Lanka – Vakarai, whose transnational links were strongly controlled by the LTTE – before moving to the shifting political engagement of the diaspora over time and in transnational space. We next analyse developments in Sri Lanka and in the diaspora after the war's end in May 2009, before suggesting conclusions on the shifts in the Sri Lankan Tamil transnational political field after the defeat of the LTTE.

Political fields: local, diasporic and transnational

Our purpose in this article is to explore the dynamics of relations between the local and diasporic and to track shifts in the political field over the course of the conflict. We see the political field as encompassing both the hostland and the homeland – and places in between. We draw on Bourdieu's notion of the 'field', and specifically the 'political field' (Bourdieu 1991; Bourdieu and Wacquant 1992), to highlight the interrelation between the local and the transnational. Bourdieu explores the ways in which groups emerge in different fields and struggle for power and influence (Thompson 1991): for him, the political field is a site of competition for power which takes the form of mobilising the right to speak and act in the name of others (Bourdieu 1991). The strength and range of the political field are dependent on agents' and institutions' ability to mobilise both within and outside the field, drawing on their various sources of 'capital' (Bourdieu 1991). Consequently, when we discuss the 'Tamil political field', we suggest that there are groups of people in Sri Lanka and in the diaspora that constitute that political field, whose power and position in the

political field derive from their ability to mobilise within and beyond that field. The political field constitutes agents that compete with each other for different visions. In the case we are examining, that vision is based on Tamil identity politics and the need for a separate homeland to pursue the Tamil cause. Exploring the ways in which power transfers and shifts between different fields helps us to understand the ways in which connections are made, modified, remade and at times broken between the diaspora and the homeland.

The notion of the political field then involves an understanding of how practices and events unfolding in any one location are dependent on and influence actors, processes and events taking place elsewhere. As we show, the LTTE's ability to mobilise the diaspora in transnational fields other than the political was key to maintaining its political, military, representational and symbolic strength at home.

For ease of exposition, we refer to a political field in Sri Lanka (the 'local political field') and a political field in the diaspora (the 'diasporic political field'), which are linked to form what we call the 'transnational political field'. Each field consists of a number of different actors operating from different locations within it. Power is accumulated, can transfer, and at times shifts between these fields. As we try to show below, in recent years, there have been ruptures in all three fields – local, diaspora and transnational – resulting in such shifts in power relations within and among them.

Sri Lankan Tamil politics became transnational in the course of the war. As we will show, the LTTE's power derived largely from its strategic control of the transnational political field. The defeat of the LTTE and the annihilation of its leadership in Sri Lanka in May 2009 fundamentally changed the dynamics of transnational politics, by greatly weakening – though not completely removing – the organisation's grip in the transnational political field.

Establishing and controlling the political field

Extrapolating from the last complete census in Sri Lanka in 1981, the country's population is approximately 20.5 million.¹ Partly as a result of the conflict, the ethnic make-up of the population is uncertain, but the commonly cited proportions drawing on the 1981 census are 74% Sinhalese, 12% Sri Lankan Tamils, 7% Muslims, 6% Indian Tamils and 1% other groups.² Since independence, Sri Lankan society has become increasingly ethnicised, as cleavages between the groups – particularly between the Tamil minority and the Sinhalese majority – have grown in significance. What follows is a necessarily brief summary account of the unfolding of Tamil politics from the 1970s to the 2000s. We show how the Tamil political field was established, institutionalised, and its reach and boundaries extended from the local to the transnational.

Militancy and violence took off in the 1970s against the background of unemployment between Sinhalese and Tamil youth (Uyangoda 1999). Several Tamil insurgent groups emerged during the 1970s, one of which, the LTTE under the leadership of Vellupillai Prabhakaran, gradually became the dominant group and the ideological powerhouse of the Tamil separatist cause. At the same time, the Sri Lankan Tamil parties formed a coalition, the Tamil United Front (from 1975 renamed Tamil United Liberation Front, TULF). In a formal resolution – the Vaddukkodai Resolution of May 1976 – they advocated a separate Tamil state in Sri Lanka, Tamil Eelam.

While the TULF campaigned for a separate state through political channels, the Tamil militant groups fought the armed forces and the police using hit-and-run warfare (Gunaratna 1998). Increased tension culminated in July 1983 with the worst civil disturbances in Sri Lanka's history. What was later termed the 'Black July' of 1983 marked the beginning of Eelam War I, the first phase of the prolonged civil war.

Political and constitutional developments further marginalised Tamils in formal political processes, and Tamil politicians played only a minor role in the unfolding of the crisis to follow (Gunaratna 1998). After Black July, support for the LTTE and a separate state increased among the Tamil population both nationally and among the Tamil diaspora, and more Tamils were recruited to the Tamil militant movements. The diminishing influence of the parliamentary political parties as the militants increasingly dominated the scene reflected a shift towards a more militarised political discourse overall: the political field was thus transformed. There were a large number of different militant groups, but from the late 1980s the LTTE succeeded in marginalising or eliminating the other Tamil groups and consolidated the organisation's monopoly (Hoole et al. 1990). Tamil politics now concentrated on the national question which overshadowed the more immediate needs and rights of the Tamil people. As the war was fought in the north and east in the 1990s, the LTTE institutionalised their power over people in the areas under their control by building up a proto-Tamil Eelam, a process which continued during a short-lived ceasefire between 2002 and 2004/2005.

However, three developments in 2004–2005 ultimately weakened the LTTE's capacity to maintain its control over both Tamils at home and abroad. The first was the break from the LTTE of its commander, Karuna, in the east and his alignment with government forces. The second was the tsunami which hit coastal areas of Sri Lanka. While the disaster initially galvanised unity and sympathy in Sri Lanka and abroad, disputes rapidly arose over the use of resources that poured in from abroad as relief for those affected by the tsunami and this tension hastened the breakdown in relations between the LTTE and the government and the escalating resumption of hostilities as 2005 wore on (see Hyndman 2007). The third was the LTTE's directive that the Tamil population should not vote in the presidential elections of November 2005, which opened the door for Mahinda Rajapakse to come to power with a hardline Sinhala-nationalist stance. These key developments were to shape the turn of events that led to the demise of the LTTE as a force in Sri Lanka. Before turning to this, we next consider how the Tamil politics just outlined played out in what we have called the local and diasporic political fields.

The local field: from a Tamil proto-state to the withdrawal of the LTTE

Connections between the diasporic field and the local field vary with social and geographical locations. International migration usually requires economic means and well-developed networks (Van Hear 2006). In the case of the Sri Lankan Tamil diaspora, the place of origin for the majority has been the Jaffna peninsula in the north of Sri Lanka, which essentially constitutes the Tamil heartland. While people in such places remain strongly connected to the diaspora through their personal social networks, for other locations and especially those more marginal places that were under LTTE control for most of the past 25 years, the linkage to the diasporic political field was less through such personal connections and almost wholly through

the LTTE. We have chosen to look at one such marginal location – Vakarai on the north-east coast of Sri Lanka – to highlight the importance of the LTTE in shaping, extending and holding together the transnational political field in such areas.

In the areas under their control, the LTTE monopolised politics, leadership, institutions and much of society in general. Some of the longest standing territories under LTTE control were the region just south of the Jaffna peninsula, known as the Vanni, where the so-called ‘final war’ was fought, and the area on the east coast known as Vakarai. During the war, the LTTE used the suffering of people living in these areas to mobilise support from the diaspora by highlighting stories of repression and dire need.

During the last 30 years, people in Vakarai have lived with ‘complex citizenship’ (Brun 2008a). By this is meant a situation where there are no clear-cut relationships between citizens and the state, but where people have to relate to several governing actors. Vakarai was a strategic area militarily and politically because it represented for the LTTE the key communication artery through which people and equipment could move between the east and the north, including the Vanni. Since 1985, people here have experienced shifting control among the army, the LTTE, the Indian Peace Keeping Force, and for a few short periods the Karuna fraction. Since the mid-1980s, the dynamics of the local political field have been shaped by the shifting balance of power between the Tamil militant groups and the government.

In periods of LTTE control, the LTTE developed their own administration from village level up to provincial levels. The new institutions involved finance, taxation, judicial systems, policing, an educational organisation and later a political wing (Brun 2008a). This institutionalisation was funded by taxing local Tamil people and by support from the diaspora. The LTTE let government offices remain in place but took over or directed many of their functions. In addition to local government functions, traditional leaders in villages were largely replaced with cadres from LTTE ranks (Sathiyasegar 2004). Even during periods of government control, the LTTE was always present and controlling the local population’s minds and activities, according to people from the area (interviews 2009). However, there was also opposition at times – most significantly represented by the split between Karuna and the LTTE that took place in Vakarai in March 2004.

Unlike the Tamil diaspora which we return to below, the population of Vakarai has been a largely immobile part of the Sri Lankan Tamil population. They have experienced multiple displacement but most often within their own area. Sometimes they were displaced for a few days, weeks or months at a time before coming back to their homes. People in Vakarai are generally poor fishermen or farmers with limited means to become part of the Sri Lankan Tamil diaspora. In this area, the role of the diaspora was not talked about in terms of political support, but mainly as financial support to the LTTE during the war.

During the ceasefire between the Sri Lankan government and the LTTE from 2002 to 2004/2005, Vakarai was under LTTE control. LTTE and government institutions ran more or less in parallel in the area. While not accepting the idea of Tamil Eelam, the state, at least in the form of local government structures, recognised the strength of the LTTE in the political field. However, as described above, relations between the LTTE and the government worsened in 2004 and from the latter part of 2005, an offensive was launched by the Sri Lankan Armed Forces in the Vakarai area, which in some ways prefigured the ‘final war’ in the Vanni during the first 5 months of 2009. People were forced to follow the LTTE when they had to

withdraw from their territories. Finally, in January 2007, people managed – against the LTTE's will – to escape and were placed in camps for internally displaced people further south in government-controlled territory. On 21 January 2007, the Sri Lankan government declared that they had regained control over Vakarai and during March/April that year, the people of Vakarai were called back by the military from their displacement. The return represented the beginning of a new understanding of the local political field and the ways in which people of Vakarai would relate to that field, which we return to below.

The defeat of the LTTE changed the political field in at least two significant ways. First, the end of LTTE control and later the elimination of the LTTE in Sri Lanka left a political and leadership vacuum among Sri Lankan Tamils. Second, it meant that in more marginal areas that had lived with LTTE control for the larger part of the past 25 years such as Vakarai, connections to the Tamil transnational political field were cut which enabled the Sri Lankan government to play a larger role in defining and controlling the political field in this area. In the next section, we move to parallel developments in the diasporic political field.

From deserters to saviours: shifts in the diasporic political field

In 1989, the long-time commentator on Sri Lankan affairs D.B.S. Jeyaraj attended a conference of the Sri Lankan Tamil diaspora held in London organised by a pro-LTTE group. Jeyaraj (2009) describes how LTTE leader Prabhakaran sent a chastening message to the conference, describing the diaspora as the 'lost generation'. This negative view was in tune with the LTTE's current perspective on the diaspora, whom it characterised as those who had left the homeland, *pulam peyarnthor*, or worse, those who had deserted Tamil Eelam at a critical point in its history.

But as time went on and fighting and violence escalated, more and more people left the homeland, the diaspora expanded and its potential to contribute to the struggle back home became more and more significant. At the same time those remaining in the north and east grew increasingly war-weary and their capacity and willingness to provide support wilted: coercion and extraction of resources for the struggle increasingly became the norm. The Tigers' revenue base on the island contracted further as LTTE control of parts of the north and east shrank after the ceasefire broke down in 2004–2005. In the final days of the war in the first part of 2009, with the LTTE confined to a diminishing strip of coastland in Mullaitivu district, the shift in the centre of gravity was completed. As Jeyaraj (2009) puts it:

Desperate, the LTTE turned to the diaspora. The wheel had turned full circle. The LTTE claiming to liberate the Tamil people now started looking to the *pulam peyarnthor* to extricate itself from the morass it had sunk into.

How did this transformation – both the rise in influence of the diaspora and the increasing importance of the diasporic political field – come about?

Conflict, diaspora formation and Tamil politics have been intricately linked since the outbreak of the war in 1983. Refugees fleeing Sri Lanka in the late 1980s made their way across the Palk Straits to Tamil Nadu in south India, or, if they could, joined earlier waves of Tamil emigrants who had left for western countries. Many of those fleeing the violence made for the UK, encouraged by the presence of compatriots already there, partly through the former colonial connection. At this stage, many of the nascent diaspora were supportive of the struggle in Sri Lanka and

contributed to the resistance groups financially and in other ways. Likewise, the Tamil population in the north and east of Sri Lanka saw the resistance groups as their defenders against an oppressive state and willingly provided support and fighters.

In the 1990s, the LTTE's control of the civilian population grew and demands on the Tamil population escalated in terms of providing fighters, resources and money through various forms of taxation. Transfers from the diaspora for the armed struggle and for relief for civilians caught in the fighting increased in this decade. Flight of refugees continued to grow during this period, again to the UK but particularly to Canada, Australia and a widening range of countries in Europe. This was a period of diaspora consolidation in the affluent countries of the west, as the various waves of arrivals embedded themselves in these societies. It was also a period when the diasporic political field rose in importance, and with it the transnational political field linking those abroad with those on the island of Sri Lanka.

Over time, the increasing pressure on the diaspora to contribute money, coupled with the increasingly authoritarian activities of the LTTE towards the Tamil civilian population, in particular taxation of impoverished and war-weary people and the recruitment of young family members, began to raise misgivings among some in the diaspora, expressed as open or tacit opposition to the LTTE, or at least much less wholehearted support. It is difficult to gauge the extent of such dissenting perspectives, and they appear to be stronger in some diaspora settings such as the UK, where oppositional groupings emerged, than in others, such as Canada and Norway, where support for the LTTE seems to have been more monolithic.

Substantial resources nevertheless continued to flow from the diaspora into the LTTE-controlled areas of the north and east, as the capacity for the civilian population in Sri Lanka to contribute dwindled. These transfers of resources contributed to the formation of a Tamil Eelam proto-state centred on Kilinochchi. The short-lived ceasefire period 2002–2004/2005 marked the high water mark of this proto-state building. Many of the diaspora paid visits for the first time in several decades to their erstwhile homes and to family members still in the north and east: during such sojourns they were taxed or otherwise contributed to reconstruction in the Tiger-controlled Vanni region.

Throughout this period, diaspora members supported family members left behind in the conflict areas, as well as sometimes collective projects – building or reconstruction of clinics, schools, libraries, orphanages and places of worship – which it was hoped would help communities to recover. The LTTE did not seem to have directly controlled such transfers and projects in the way they mediated and controlled linkages between the diaspora and Sri Lankan Tamil civilians in the political sphere. Control over the diaspora, if they were not forthcoming with sufficient support for the LTTE, could nevertheless be maintained by tacit or overt threats to kinsfolk back in Sri Lanka.

As already noted, LTTE control over the civilian population was tacitly recognised by the government during the ceasefire. Crucially, its monopolistic hold over both parts of the Tamil population – at home and abroad – meant that the LTTE also controlled linkages in the political field between the diaspora and the civilian population – what we have called the transnational political field. The monopoly eased somewhat during the ceasefire when many diaspora members visited the Jaffna peninsula to meet family members and communities left long ago. Home Town and Old School Associations revived during this period, focusing on community level reconstruction and recovery. At the same time, returning

diasporans got a taste of the treatment meted out to the local Tamil population under LTTE control, through taxation and other experiences which jarred with the liberal values of diaspora members living in western countries.

With the resumption of the war in 2005, and increasingly concerned to raise resources, the LTTE tried to reassert greater control over both the diaspora and local civilians – and the connections between them. However the war-weary civilian population was unable to contribute much more: funding drives were therefore pitched in diaspora strongholds for funding the ‘final war’ (Human Rights Watch 2006). Fundraising efforts intensified at mass gatherings and through knocking on doors. LTTE assertion of control over institutions in the Tamil diaspora, especially temples, but also schools, housing bodies and cultural and sports organisations, hardened in the increasingly desperate search for resources. The diasporic political field had become crucial for the organisation’s very survival.

The political field after the war

In the final stages of the war, LTTE gradually closed down their structures and institutions. Kilinochchi, the political and administrative capital of the LTTE, was taken by government forces in January 2009. The whole administration and all the people including the LTTE had moved away in the traditional way that LTTE operated in such circumstances: moving out before the government forces moved in. Gradually from 2005, the LTTE withdrew first to the remaining territories it controlled and then gradually towards the small land-strip on the coast until its final defeat in May 2009.

This article has so far shown how the Sri Lankan Tamil political field came to be dominated by the LTTE. We have shown how the political field gradually became transnational in the sense that LTTE held its grip on people and politics in the diaspora and in the Tamil dominated areas of Sri Lanka. By way of violence, force, institutional developments and physical presence among Tamils in Sri Lanka and in the diaspora, the LTTE had over the years gained acceptance as the sole representative of the Sri Lankan Tamil population. The events of May 2009, when the LTTE was defeated and the leadership killed, meant a profound shift in the relationship between people and locations in the Tamil political field when the relationship between agents operating *inside* Sri Lanka and *outside* changed. The LTTE had been the most important agent of local/diasporic connections in the Tamil transnational political field. One may argue that this was an unhealthy monopoly of Tamil transnational politics nurturing identity politics based on uncompromising and non-democratic representational practices. However, as the LTTE hierarchy, institutions and networks unravelled in Sri Lanka, the link between diaspora politics and homeland politics was ruptured. In this section, we reflect on the developments after May 2009 and how Tamil politics has changed, driven by shifts in the connections between the local and the diasporic political fields.

From a transnational Tamil political field to the one-nation narrative

The defeat of the LTTE influenced the local political field and the ways in which that field could play into the transnational political field. In areas like Vakarai, the defeat of the LTTE cut the link to the transnational political field due to the relative lack of diaspora influence outside LTTE mediation. As we have indicated, not many people

from Vakaraï had joined the Tamil diaspora, and consequently, there were few connections between people in Vakaraï and the diaspora.

The return of people to the areas in March/April 2007 represented the beginning of a new period. People who had returned to Vakaraï expressed feelings of relief and loss at the same time: loss due to the war experiences and the withdrawal of the LTTE; relief after having experienced the marginalisation, the fear, the forced abduction of their children by the LTTE and control by the government in conditions of complex citizenship as described above. Their lives were easier now they said as they were serving only one master, the Sri Lankan government, which stepped in where the LTTE once held sway to reshape the political field away from the transnational and into the national arena.

The return and recovery may be understood in the context of the government's strategy to establish a 'one-nation, one country' narrative on the island after the defeat of the LTTE. In Vakaraï, this strategy materialised in a militarised system of governance with close collaboration between the military and the Divisional Secretariat through a civil coordinator. The recovery programme involved re-establishing government structures, reconstructing houses, hospital and medical services and providing electricity, water and roads.

Among the projects was the rebuilding and extension of Vakaraï school funded by the European Union and built under the coordination of the International Organisation for Migration. The school, believed to be the largest, most modern and technically advanced school in Batticaloa District, was opened by President Rajapakse on 22 September 2009. In his address to the incoming pupils, the president said: 'Coupled with quality education, you should also cultivate good moral habits and humane qualities to become a good and productive citizen' (Daily News 2009). During the opening, the students had to sing the national anthem in Sinhala with which they were not familiar: tellingly, to accomplish this task they needed help from soldiers stationed in Vakaraï.

Mobilisation for the idea of one nation also took other forms. One significant example was the celebration of the Sri Lankan independence day, which was not marked during LTTE control. In February 2009, the LTTE was no longer in the area and the government was just about to win the war. The president ordered everyone in Sri Lanka to hoist the Sri Lankan national flag at their house gates. In Vakaraï, the authorities drove through the areas with speakers announcing that everyone had to put up flags to mark the national day. People conformed to this requirement but expressed their frustration at being told to do so. Some spent a day's salary to travel by bus through the checkpoints towards Batticaloa to buy the flags that could not be obtained in Vakaraï. Two years later, in March 2011, we inquired whether people had been told to put up flags on the independence day. 'No, we were not asked, but we did put up flags' they said. 'Why', we asked; 'we just did', was the answer. Partly through coercion and partly as a strategy to cope with those in power, people gradually appeared to accept the 'one-nation' narrative which illustrates one of the ways in which the Sri Lankan government has managed to mobilise and redefine the political field in Vakaraï.

The practices within the one-nation narrative influence the ways in which people in Vakaraï relate to and engage in transnational fields. As we discussed above, to understand the dynamics of a political field, we need to understand political actors' ability to mobilise outside that field. In Vakaraï, people have lost the link to the diaspora mediated through the LTTE, but the events taking place in Vakaraï may

influence or still be influenced by the transnational political field. In Sri Lanka more widely, the discourse on the Tamil diaspora and its various engagements in the transnational political field, discussed in the next section, has emerged in a very critical light and has been cast as a threat to Sri Lankan sovereignty. On 15 March 2011, for example, the government-controlled Daily News quoted the president characterising the diaspora as ‘... elements try(ing) to distort the image of Sri Lanka’ (Daily News 2011). Engaging with the transnational political field from within Sri Lanka is therefore increasingly difficult, even if there had been links with the diaspora in the past.

At the same time, people in Vakaraï have begun to engage modestly with other transnational fields, particularly the economic field as part of a strategy for recovery and employment. Since the end of the war, a small but growing number of people, mainly women, have begun migrating from Vakaraï district to the Middle East as domestic and other workers. Local development organisations and civil society groups reported in interviews in March 2011 that in some villages approximately 5% of households had people who had gone abroad to work – almost all since the end of the war in this area in 2007. While this proportion is small compared with the rural communities of the south of the country, it is a significant and increasing development connecting this formerly isolated district to Sri Lanka’s Gulf labour migration stream and to the general development discourse of the country, which underlines the shift in the political field in this area.

The mixed legacy of the LTTE in the diaspora

As these developments played out in particular locations like Vakaraï in Sri Lanka, the diaspora looked on largely powerless as the endgame played out in the first half of 2009. By then, many of the old guard of LTTE activists and supporters were weary after decades of struggle. Some space had opened up for more open initiatives exploring alternatives to the LTTE monopoly among some of what might be called the ‘middle guard’ – those who had left as youths or children in the 1980s and were now in middle age. Several of this generation had fallen foul of the LTTE or had come to disagree with the movement’s military and political strategy, tactics and actions – particularly its treatment of dissidents and civilians. The most striking development in the diaspora however was the rapid emergence in 2008–2010 of activism by second and ‘1.5’ generation Tamils (the latter being those who left Sri Lanka as small children), who had now come of age. Large demonstrations were mobilised in the main centres of Tamil population in affluent western countries to protest at the plight of civilians caught up in the final chapter of the war. The diasporic political field was rejuvenated and reinvigorated.

Following the defeat of the LTTE in Sri Lanka in May 2009, a number of groupings could be identified in the diasporic political field, reflecting different strands of thinking and ideology and manifested organisationally to different degrees. One such grouping was the LTTE ‘old guard’, the rump of the LTTE which included the remnants of the organisation, who had got out before the endgame in Sri Lanka, or were already outside the country. Related to but distinct from this grouping is what might be called the ‘LTTE legacy’ or ‘LTTE heritage’. Many of these were younger generation activists mentioned above, who came to the fore in the large-scale mobilisations of 2009 and 2010. More liberal and democratic than the hard core rump, they promoted a more moderate nationalism. Meanwhile, there was

also a modest resurgence outside the LTTE of more open discussion of possible ways forward, with various fora emerging which reached out with varying success to some of the new younger activists, and even some sympathetic Sinhalese and Muslims. At the same time, there was a harder opposition to the LTTE, principally those associated with the Karuna group, but also the remnants of the groups that had rivalled or splintered away from the LTTE in the 1980s. These were the main activist fractions. The Tamil diaspora population at large varied in its orientation, from enthusiastic to passive or grudging support for one or other of these positions – or none of them.

Within this complex milieu, several significant institutional initiatives emerged from mid-2009, mainly from within the ‘LTTE legacy’ as the defeat of the LTTE sank in among the diaspora. First, the Global Tamil Forum (GTF) was set up as an umbrella grouping for national level Tamil groupings, including the British Tamil Forum, the Canadian Tamil Congress, and similar French, Australian, Norwegian and other national groupings. The GTF held a successful launch in February 2010 in the British parliament, attended by delegates from 15 countries with significant Tamil diaspora populations and addressed by high profile British politicians (against the background of impending elections in the UK). Second, a referendum on the Vaddukkodai Resolution (see ‘Establishing and controlling the political field’, above), reasserting the need for an independent Tamil homeland, was held in most major diaspora locations from mid-2009 to early 2010. In a process which monitors attested was well-run, most of those who voted appeared to reaffirm the resolution and thereby the need for a separate state of Tamil Eelam. Third, there were moves towards the formation of a Transnational Government of Tamil Eelam (TGTE). The TGTE’s founding documents drew heavily on scholarly discourse on transnationalism and diaspora (Advisory Committee of the TGTE 2010). The initiative was met with scepticism both among hardliners in the LTTE rump and among more liberal elements in the diaspora who saw it as an attempt to revive a defunct LTTE. In the event, a number of the LTTE rump stood and were elected as representatives. Elections were held in early May 2010, and the inaugural meeting of the TGTE constituent assembly was held in transnational session in Philadelphia, London, Geneva and other diaspora constituencies in mid-May 2010 (Office of the Interim Chief Executive of the TGTE 2010).

The diasporic political field was thus in process of being remade from 2009 as different groups within the diaspora jostled for power by drawing on different constituencies for their political capital and by pursuing a variety of institutional forms. While these various initiatives had varying levels of support among different fractions of the Tamil diaspora, they had very little purchase among the Tamils in Sri Lanka whose cause they claimed to espouse, underlining the apparently now large disconnect between the Tamil diaspora and those back home: effectively a transformation of the transnational political field. It is to this diaspora/local disjuncture and, more broadly, the shifts in the centre of gravity of Tamil politics that we now turn.

Local, diasporic and transnational: the shifting centre of gravity in the political field

Views differ widely on the degree of convergence of perspective between those in the diaspora and those in Sri Lanka, particularly on whether an independent Tamil state is possible or even desirable. An interview with Visuvanathan Rudrakumaran, Prime

Minister of the TGTE (Azwer 2011), sets out the position widely held by many in the diaspora:

... the diaspora is an integrated part of the Tamil Nation. The Tamils living in the island and outside are one entity. As long as the Tamils living in the island do not have the political space to fully articulate their political aspirations, the diaspora living around the world in liberal democratic countries have to undertake that task.

Critics of the LTTE in the diaspora took a very different position. Writing in the final stages of the war, a month before the military defeat of the LTTE in May 2009, Nirmala Rajasingam, a long-time activist who had left the LTTE and become highly critical of it, highlighted the disparity between the diaspora and those left in the conflict zones:

... the huge demonstrations in the west that endorse the LTTE are in direct opposition to the waning popular support for the LTTE amongst Tamils in Sri Lanka itself. The eastern region of Sri Lanka where many Tamils live – and which has lost far more of its young people and children in this war than any other Tamil region – has largely abandoned support for an independent state. The Jaffna peninsula in the north has been largely uninvolved for more than a decade or so in the separatist cause; there, the vast majority of civilians have submitted to uneasy cohabitation with the army simply because amid available options, they prefer an absence of war. The LTTE's cynical and callous use of civilians for its war effort has also over the years undermined its status within the Tamil population in Sri Lanka. (Rajasingham 2009)

Such views were echoed by outside observers. One of the most comprehensive explorations of the Tamil diaspora in the wake of the defeat of the LTTE in May 2009 was by the International Crisis Group (ICG 2010). The study suggested that the views of those in the diaspora and those in Sri Lanka were far apart:

... most Tamils abroad remain profoundly committed to Tamil Eelam, the existence of a separate state in Sri Lanka. This has widened the gap between the diaspora and Tamils in Sri Lanka. Most in the country are exhausted by decades of war and are more concerned with rebuilding their lives under difficult circumstances than in continuing the struggle for an independent state. (ICG 2010, i)

Others, often within the Tamil diaspora itself – in cyberspace and the blogosphere in particular – argue that this disconnection has been overstated. Providing a usefully nuanced understanding portrayal of post-war Tamil transnational politics, Vimalarajah and Cheran (2010) have underlined the social and political cleavages within the diaspora and the lack of complete correspondence between diaspora politics and those of the LTTE: support for Tamil nationalism and support for the LTTE were not coterminous, they argue. This implied greater convergence between some members of the diaspora and some of those at home, and greater divergence between other members of both groups. The argument went that it was hardly surprising that Tamils in Sri Lanka are keeping their heads down in the context of government triumphalism and the government's 'one-nation, one country' narrative.

On the face of it however, the outcome of the defeat of the LTTE in Sri Lanka and the weakening of the organisation's grip over the transnational political field does appear to have been a significant divergence in outlook and aspirations between Tamils in Sri Lanka and those in the diaspora. In the April 2010 elections, the war-weary Tamil population seemed to voice a wish for a democratic and peaceful

solution and recovery within a unified Sri Lanka after living with war and marginalisation for more than 25 years. However, there was still a strong discourse of and mobilisation for a separate homeland in the diasporic political field. The centre of gravity for this perspective in terms of the transnational political field had shifted from the LTTE operating in northern and eastern Sri Lanka to institutions and organisations such as the GTF and the TGTE in the diaspora, albeit with an increasing number of dissenting voices.

Conclusion

In this article, we have shown how the Sri Lankan Tamil transnational political field has been shaped by events in Sri Lanka and by the formation of the Tamil diaspora. We have explained how the field has changed by looking at shifts in the local and diasporic political fields, and how the two fields have played into one another to shape the transnational political field. We have traced how the connections between the local and diasporic political fields have been weakened and consequently the transnational political field has been thrown into flux. Key to understanding this transformation is that the most significant agent in the transnational field, the LTTE, was eliminated as a political force in Sri Lanka in May 2009.

At the same time, other diasporic links with the homeland have continued to be sustained through internet and phone links, visits, participation in weddings and other life course events, and private and community-based remittances and other transfers of resources. Families and individuals in the diaspora continue to send money to relatives in Sri Lanka, and through home town associations and old school associations in particular, people continue to donate resources for the development of education, health care and other projects in local communities.

The impact of such diaspora connections and transnational practices is uneven however. While Jaffna may well recover and eventually thrive through such transnational linkages, as we have shown, marginal places like Vakarai, whose only connection with the diaspora in the past was through the LTTE, are unlikely to benefit much from such diaspora engagement in the future. In so far as they are entering the transnational arena, it is through labour migration to the Middle East: this implies that the area is being incorporated into the form of development associated with transnationalism elsewhere in the country, where such labour migration is prevalent, all of which fits into the government discourse on national economic development. Thus, both geographical and sociopolitical locations will continue to shape the possibilities for and content of transnational connections and the benefits they may or may not bring.

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Notes

1. Department of Census and Statistics: <http://www.statistics.gov.lk/home.asp> (accessed 25 May 2010).
2. 'Muslim' is considered an ethnic group in Sri Lanka. 'Indian Tamils' were brought by the British in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries to work in plantations or estates and are a group distinct from much longer settled 'Sri Lankan Tamils'.

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